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Reports of Meetings of Experts and Equivalent Bodies

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Eighth Session

Online

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Executive Summary

The eighth session of the OBIS Executive Committee was chaired by SG-OBIS Co-Chairs Katherine Tattersall and Dan Lear and met for two 2-hour online sessions on the 15th and 24th June 2026. The committee reviewed progress on the 2026 OBIS work plan with reports from the Secretariat and the Nodes, Data and Products Coordination Groups, and set direction for the 2027 and 2028–2029 work plans and budget within the UNESCO-IOC results framework. The Committee also prepared for SG-OBIS-14 (pre-meeting session online Sept 2026, and Ostend, 11–16 Nov 2026), addressed succession of Coordination and Steering Group Co-Chairs, and mapped OBIS involvement in upcoming events.

Key EC-OBIS recommendations and action items

BBNJ. The Committee took note of the outcomes of the BBNJ PrepCom process and welcomed the Secretariat's and SG Co-Chair's active engagement. It thanked Norway for NORAD funding that will enable OBIS to prepare for BBNJ implementation, including support for digital sequence information, and invited other Member States to provide comparable support. The Committee suggested that the 36-node OBIS federated network might be positioned as regional and national entry points for the BBNJ Clearing-House Mechanism, and it called on countries to leverage on and resource existing OBIS capabilities rather than establishing parallel or duplicative structures.

Staffing and funding. The Committee stressed that filling the vacant OBIS data-manager (P-3) position, for which recruitment has restarted, is a critical priority, particularly as several posts will fall vacant in 2027. It thanked IODE for allocating Regular Programme resources in an environment of severe IOC budget reductions and asked the IOC Secretariat to sustain its resource-mobilisation efforts, noting that the regular programme budget alone supports only a project-management function and limited resources for implementation of the work plan.

Communications and the OBIS brand. The Committee underlined the strategic value of the OBIS brand, built over 26 years of community-driven work. It expressed the expectation that the IOC will engage with OBIS through a collaborative process via the IODE Steering Group for OBIS to develop branding guidelines, well ahead of the new IOC visual identity to be finalised at the 34th IOC Assembly in June 2027.

Coordination Groups. The Committee welcomed the progress reported by the Nodes, Data and Products Coordination Groups. It supported the plan to hire a part-time helpdesk officer shared with ODIS, noted that the FUST-funded MOZAIK project will substantially strengthen the Products Coordination Group, and encouraged broader participation across the node network given the groups' largely voluntary structure.

Ways forward

Planning the 2028–2029 work plan. The Committee agreed to review the 2026 work plan to identify activities that should roll over into 2027 and to develop the OBIS work plan 2028-2029 drafting methodology. Strengthening the node network, node onboarding, capacity development and a communications toolkit for Member States should remain priorities.

Succession of Co-Chairs. The Committee recommended that coordination Group Co-Chairs are to inform the Secretariat and the Co-Chairs of their intention to serve a second term or step down at least three months before SG-OBIS-14. The Committee also agreed to bring forward to SG-OBIS-14 a proposal to align the SG-OBIS Co-Chair terms with the IOC rules of procedure, defining a term as two years and allowing a Co-Chair to serve normally up to two terms, or four years.

Next milestones. The key milestones ahead are SG-OBIS-14 in Ostend from 11 to 16 November 2026 and BBNJ COP-1 in New York from 11 to 22 January 2027, alongside continued OBIS engagement at IOC, GBIF, TDWG, CBD COP-17 and related events.

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1. Opening and adoption of agenda

Katherine Tattersall and Dan Lear, SG-OBIS Co-Chairs, opened the meeting and requested the OBIS executive committee members to adopt the agenda. The meeting was held in two online sessions of 2 hours each.

The EC-OBIS adopted the agenda.

The list of participants is available in Annex 1.

2. Progress reports OBIS workplan 2026

The Co-Chairs invited the OBIS secretariat and Coordination Group Co-Chairs to report on progress towards the delivery of the OBIS work plan. Reports should focus on current challenges, the management of any issues or risks, and any changes or adjustments required to the previously endorsed work plan.

2.1. Progress report OBIS secretariat

2.1.1. Overall progress and highlights

Ward Appeltans, head of OBIS secretariat introduced this agenda item and listed the progress of action items related to the OBIS secretariat in Table 1. In addition, in the first 5.5 months of 2026 we can report the following statistics:

- 32 million new records published (see figure 1A)
- 215 new datasets (see figure 1B)
- 97 new OBIS cited publications (2025 had a record number: 251 publications)
- On LinkedIn: 97,991 impressions; 1,773 reactions and 1,968 new followers (5,966 in total)

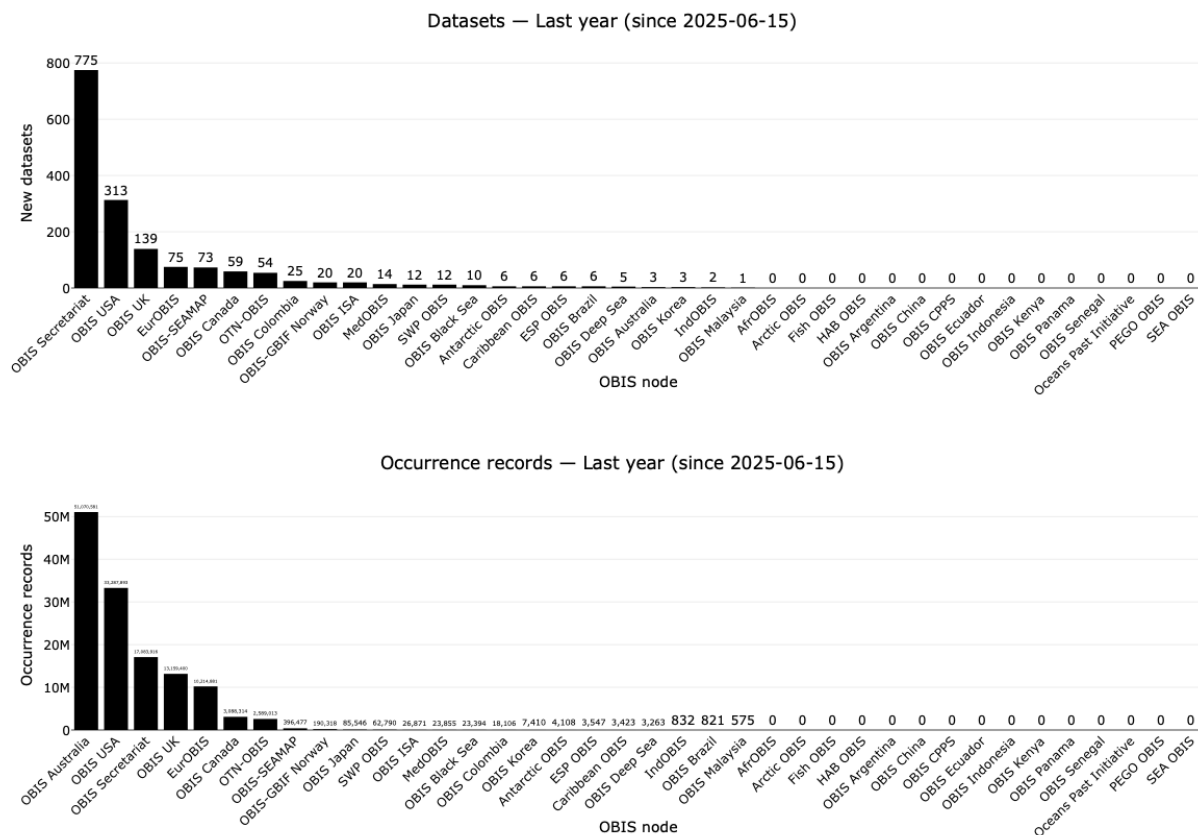


Figure 1. Number of new datasets (a) and new occurrence records (b) published in OBIS by OBIS node. The number of new datasets from the secretariat is high because of harvesting EBI/Mgnify.

Table 1: Status of action items from SG-OBIS-13 related to the OBIS secretariat

Action items from SG-OBIS-13	Status
The SG-OBIS thanked the Flanders Government for hosting the OBIS secretariat since 2012 and stressed that the renewal of the host agreement between Flanders and IOC is important for the continuation and success of OBIS.	No progress to date. The MOU expires 31 Dec 2026. Updated: at IOC-EC59, Flanders announced that it will renew the MOU.
The SG-OBIS stressed the importance of re-opening the recruitment of the OBIS data manager position as soon as possible. The lack of a stable technical position in the OBIS secretariat is a serious risk and one that we cannot afford with the growing demand on OBIS to deliver critical services and support to the ocean community.	In progress. The recruitment has re-started.
The SG-OBIS welcomed opportunities to	Plan drafted but not shared. Several big

explore the capacity to diversify the funding available to OBIS. The SG-OBIS decided to establish an IWG to explore a fund raising strategy and report back to the SG.	funding streams are in the pipeline at IOC led by the IOC Exec Sec.
The SG-OBIS welcomed the evolution of the OBIS Communication Strategy and requested periodic updates on its implementation.	See below: item 2.1.3
The SG-OBIS requested the OBIS Secretariat to set up a mechanism to support regular reporting of project aims and outcomes to ensure alignment with the OBIS workplan.	In progress, as part of the website

2.1.2. Biodiversity Beyond National Jurisdiction (BBNJ)

Ward Appeltans reported that the OBIS secretariat has been actively engaged in the BBNJ process and attended the three PrepCom meetings in New York. BBNJ was ratified on 17 Jan 2026 and the first COP will take place in New York on 11-22 January 2027. OBIS has been referenced by several countries during the PrepCom process, especially in the context of the BBNJ's Clearing-House Mechanism - which essentially will be a centralized information management system built on a federated, node-based architecture of data systems.

OBIS already runs a federated network of 36 regional, national and thematic nodes that serve as the authoritative source of truth for their data, retain sovereignty over what they publish, and feed a centrally harvested, integrated and quality-controlled global platform. OBIS nodes could serve as the CHM's regional and national entry points for submitting and brokering biodiversity data relevant to area-based management tools and environmental impact assessments; deliver the distributed capacity-building, helpdesk and multilingual support the Mechanism will need close to data providers, especially for SIDS and LDCs in low-bandwidth settings; bridge the CHM to existing national data systems so States are not forced to build parallel infrastructure; and prove, through an established governance and data-sovereignty framework, that a global mechanism can be run without centralising all underlying data or eroding national control.

The BBNJ CHM will be managed by the BBNJ secretariat, but according to article 51 may decide to work with (technical) partners such as IOC. We will need to see what will be decided as the most practical appropriate mechanism. However, it is important that Member States build on and not duplicate OBIS capabilities locally.

To support OBIS to prepare for BBNJ requirements, NORAD has provided funding to adapt OBIS, so it can handle digital sequence information and meets the requirements from the BBNJ agreement (e.g. reports based on BBNJ MGR standardized batch identifier).

The EC-OBIS took note of the outcomes of the BBNJ PrepCom process and welcomed the involvement of the OBIS secretariat.

The EC-OBIS conveyed its appreciation to Norway for the financial contribution that enables OBIS to prepare for BBNJ implementation. The EC-OBIS invited other Member States to consider providing comparable support.

The EC-OBIS recommended that BBNJ-related guidance and engagement opportunities be developed as part of the communication toolkit made available to OBIS nodes. It underlined the importance of raising awareness among Member States of the role that existing OBIS nodes could play within the BBNJ Clearing-House Mechanism, and called on countries to build on the established federated node network rather than establishing parallel or duplicative national structures.

2.1.3. Staff and financial situation

The OBIS work plan 2026-2027¹ was submitted to the IODE Management Group meeting in January 2026. The annual budget that OBIS put forward to the IODE MG was close to US\$ 150,000 - which was similar to the budget that was allocated to OBIS in the previous period. However, due to the 23% short-fall in UNESCO's budget, programmes are on average cut by 60%. The allocated annual budget to OBIS is now in the range of US\$75,000 (see table below).

Activity	Annual budget requested	Annual budget allocated
Infrastructure costs		
JupyterHub Instance for 5 active users at a time with 16GB RAM or for 100 active users with 64GB RAM	\$5,000	\$0
Long term storage and associated operational costs, Communication platform subscriptions, Notion subscriptions	\$20,000	\$20,000
Travel, meetings and purchases		
SG-OBIS-14 catering and travel sec + executive	\$45,000	\$15,000
Communication & outreach material	\$9,500	\$5,000
OBIS Secretariat Staff		
OBIS Program Manager	Covered by UNESCO	Covered by UNESCO
OBIS Technical and Scientific Coordinator	Covered by UNESCO	Not yet filled

¹ <https://oceanexpert.org/document/37804>

OBIS IT/Data Manager	EXB funded	EXB funded
OBIS Training Officer	EXB funded	EXB funded
OBIS Researcher/product Officer	EXB funded	EXB funded
OBIS Community Helpdesk Officer (combined with ODIS)	\$66,000	\$66,000
OBIS Community Engagement & Communications Officer	EXB funded	EXB funded
OBIS/MBO Stakeholder Engagement Officer	EXB funded	EXB funded
OBIS eDNA Operations Officer	EXB funded	EXB funded
OBIS eDNA Science Officer	EXB funded	EXB funded
OBIS Admin Officer	EXB funded	EXB funded
	\$145,500	\$73,000

The EC-OBIS expressed its appreciation to IODE for allocating resources to OBIS under the IOC Regular Programme, recognising the difficult context of severe budget reductions across IOC. It regretted that the reduced funding leaves no capacity to support in-person attendance of the annual OBIS Steering Group meetings by nodes from the Global South, and requested the Secretariat to explore options for enabling virtual participation.

Ward Appeltans continued and reported that several extra-budgetary projects are ending in 2026 and 2027:

- eDNAquaPlan (end date 31 August 2026)
- MARCO-BOLO (end date 30 Nov 2026)
- MPA Europe (31 July 2026 - no-cost extension of 3 months)
- DTO-BioFlow (end date 28 February 2027)
- BIOES Feasibility Study (end date 28 Feb 2026)
- BioEcoOcean ends 31 January 2028.

However, new projects started or will start:

- eDNA expeditions 2026-2028 (end date 31 Dec 2028)
- MOZAIEK: 1 Jan 2027-31 Dec 2029
- NORAD BBNJ: 1 Jan 2026-31 Dec 2027

Below is an overview of the current status of the OBIS secretariat staffing and the sources of funding. For several team members, 2027 is still uncertain - however 3 new positions will become vacant in 2027 in addition to the yet unfilled OBIS P-3 position.

	2026	2027
Ward Appeltans	UNESCO	UNESCO
Steve Formel	MARCO-BOLO	/
Silas Principe	MPA Europe, DTO-BioFlow	FUST MOZAIEK
Elizabeth Lawrence	EU BioEcoOcean	EU BioEcoOcean
Pieter Provoost	BBNJ NORAD, eDNA Expeditions, DTO-BioFlow	eDNA Expeditions, ?
Lisa Benedetti	EU MARCO-BOLO	/
Saara Suominen	eDNA Expeditions	eDNA Expeditions
Emilie Boulanger	EU eDNAquaPlan, eDNA Expeditions	eDNA Expeditions
Laurent Chmiel	eDNA Expeditions, OBIS special account	eDNA Expeditions, FUST MOZAIEK
Celia Marlowe	BIOES	/
Mithona Prak	eDNA Expeditions	/
IT Developer (NEW)		FUST MOZAIEK
Admin officer (NEW)		eDNA Expeditions, FUST MOZAIEK
OBIS-ODIS Helpdesk officer (NEW)		IODE RP

2.1.4. New project Proposals

Ward Appeltans reported that OBIS is and has been involved in several project proposals. The success rate however has been variable. So far only MOZAIEK has been successful.

Project Title: Digital Twin Ocean Application Tools For Sustainable Decision-Making (DTO4SUSTAIN)

Funding Call: HORIZON-MISS-2025-03-OCEAN-08

Role for OBIS: OBIS is a project partner and policy co-developer across several regional use cases, including the Atlantic and Arctic Oceans, the Baltic and North Seas, the Mediterranean, and the Danube/Black Sea regions. OBIS serves as a primary biodiversity data repository and

provides species distribution models (SDMs) to fill data gaps and inform future ecosystem projections.

Resources for OBIS: 11 person-months across the four work packages.

Status: Rejected

Project Title: Establishing Strictly Protected Areas To Benefit Biodiversity And Fisheries In European Seas (STRICTMPA)

Funding Call: HORIZON-MISS-2025-03-OCEAN-01

Role for OBIS: OBIS leads biodiversity mapping and the development of state-of-the-art abundance-based Species Distribution Models (aSDM). OBIS serves as the primary repository for biological data and will host the expanded European MPA Atlas. Additionally, OBIS leads the project's Data Management Plan and provides global training and capacity building through the OceanTeacher Global Academy (OTGA).

Resources for OBIS: 37.5 person-months of staff effort across the three work packages

Status: Rejected

Project Title: Coral Triangle - Coral Ocean Resilience Expedition (CT-CORE)

Funding Call: HORIZON-CL6-2025-01-BIODIV-07

Role for OBIS: OBIS leads the project's data management strategy and serves as a primary global repository for its biodiversity data.

Resources for OBIS: 14.25 person-months of staff effort to OBIS across the various work packages

Status: Rejected

Project Title: Heatwave Observation and Tracking System for Early Alerts on Marine Life Impacts: From Prediction to Coastal Community Response (HOTSEA)

Funding Call: BNP Paribas Foundation Climate & Biodiversity Initiative 2025 call for projects - Ocean & Coastal Ecosystems

Role for OBIS: Coordinator and implementer of the project

Resources for OBIS: approximately 0.5M EUR

Status: Rejected

Project Title: Modular Biodiversity Data Infrastructure for Ocean Applications (MOZAIEK)

Funding Call: Flanders-UNESCO Science Trust Fund (FUST) phase 6 (2024-2028) second call.

Role for OBIS: Coordinator and implementer of the project

Resources for OBIS: approximately 1M EUR

Status: Accepted

OBIS has been invited to participate in three more Horizon Europe proposals with submission deadline mid September 2026. Our exact role and budget is still under discussion. The proposals respond to the following calls:

- HORIZON-CL6-2026-01-BIODIV-04: Ensuring continuous effectiveness of protected areas in conserving habitats and species while facing intensifying drivers of biodiversity loss
- HORIZON-MISS-2026-03-OCEAN-05: Regional (sea-basins) components of the EU Digital Twin Ocean
- HORIZON-CL6-2026-01-BIODIV-03: Pushing The Frontier Of Knowledge And Conservation Action For Deep Sea Ecosystems

The EC-OBIS thanked the IOC Secretariat and its OBIS team for their ongoing resource mobilisation efforts and requested the IOC Secretariat to continue this work, noting that the current core budget allocations alone are insufficient to sustain more than a project management function.

2.1.5. Technical developments

Pieter Provoost, OBIS data manager, reported that core OBIS technical developments have focused on a refactoring of the OBIS pipeline with a number of goals in mind: better performance, the ability to handle larger datasets (eDNA in particular), the ability to disable indexing for certain extensions by dataset, support for eDNA datasets with Event core, and making the pipeline better suitable to add support for Darwin Core Data Package at a later stage. Tagging of datasets, for example by EOVS, has been implemented in OBIS, but a reliable workflow for identifying datasets associated with specific EOVS is still under development.

From June 2026 onwards we will start a review of the new DwC-DP data model and the implications for the OBIS infrastructure. Implementation of DwC-DP is likely going to present some challenges as it significantly increases complexity and it impacts all aspects of the OBIS operations and infrastructure, from publishing to indexing and data access. We will coordinate the technical implementation as much as possible with GBIF.

2.1.6. Extra-budgetary projects

2.1.6.1. eDNA expeditions 2026-2028

Saara Suominen, eDNA Expeditions operations officer, reported that the eDNA Expeditions 2026-2028 project kicked off in January 2026, with an open call and the selection of 25 participating sites among the 650+ applications from 113 countries received in the first months. As of today 14 out of 25 sites have signed the consent form formalizing their participation in the project with all necessary authorisations and permits. After review from the scientific advisory board, the project delivered a detailed implementation plan to each site that signed the consent form and held a science call with the first four sites to co-develop their science and sampling plans.

The response to this call for sites to join the initiative has made evident the remarkable momentum and interest that the eDNA Expeditions has generated across the global community. We are currently in discussion with the project funder regarding the possibility of securing additional extra-budgetary resources to expand the initiative to an estimated 100 sites through one-off sampling campaigns as a complementary strand of the project, as it offers an accessible entry point for countries at varying stages of scientific capacity and represents an important vehicle for inclusive, equitable participation in global ocean science.

Currently, three OBIS nodes are directly involved in the project. **OBIS Malaysia** is directly involved with Muhammad Hafiz Bin Borkhanud as scientific lead for the participation of the Pulau Redang Marine Park in Terengganu, Malaysia. **OBIS Colombia** is directly involved with Vanessa Yepes-Narváez as the scientific lead for the participation of the Gorgona National Park in the Colombian Pacific. And **OBIS Japan** is involved with Takashi Hosono supporting the participation of the Northern Okinawa Island, Japan. Additionally, **Caribbean OBIS**, through Eduardo Klein, and **OBIS Ecuador**, through Victor Chocho, were consulted for the involvement of the Venezuelan Morrocoy National Park and the Ecuadorian Galapagos Marine Reserve respectively. As the project progresses and sites develop their Science Plan, we will work to include more OBIS nodes into the data management of participating sites (Table 2).

Aside from coordinating the development of 25 locally led molecular observatories of marine biodiversity worldwide, the project plans to develop DNA-based biodiversity data management training materials that will contribute directly to the OBIS work plan (Outcome 5.; D5.5; and KPI 5.5). Saara Suominen also leads the OBIS DCG subgroup on DNA data where the review of OBIS guidelines on eDNA data is discussed as well as the needs for DNA data training. Also Emilie Boulanger (eDNA expeditions science officer) is involved in developing the training materials for the OBIS Node DNA-derived data training, which will take place on the 2nd of July 2026, the DNA-derived Data Management Course organised at INVEMAR by OBIS Colombia from 21-24 July 2026, and the DNA data management workshop for the Global eDNA Conference in Seattle, USA, on the 27th of October 2026. There is however no dedicated training officer within the project, and the recurrent requests for DNA-derived data management training and training on molecular methods and data analysis from participating sites emphasize the need for such a dedicated role going forward.

Pieter Provoost reported that a data platform has been developed for the project to handle the entire workflow from site applications and metadata management to bioinformatics and connections to external systems such as ENA and OBIS.

Table 2. Overview of the 14 sites participating in eDNA Expeditions 2026-2028 that have signed the consent form to date, the OBIS nodes directly involved (in bold) and the OBIS nodes that could potentially be involved.

Site	Country	Ecological issue(s) brought to the project	Nodes directly involved in bold // Reg./nat. Nodes that could potentially be involved
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iSimangaliso Wetland Park	South Africa	Detection of missed species (e.g. sea turtles), spatial patterns and genetic diversity under climate change	// AfrOBIS
Calanques National Park	France	Climate-linked tropical/southern species, community shifts, rare species in strictly protected zones	// MedOBIS, EurOBIS
Saltfjorden and Saltstraumen	Norway	Inside/outside MPA comparison, invasive species (pink salmon, red king crab), algal bloom dynamics from eutrophication	// OBIS-GBIF Norway, EurOBIS
Sundarbans Reserve Forest	Bangladesh	Seasonal/annual change in fish, shrimp, crab, turtle and dolphin communities in a major mangrove ecosystem	// IndOBIS
Northern Okinawa	Japan	Effects of rapid ocean warming on marine life along the Kuroshio Current	OBIS Japan //
Terengganu (Redang Marine Park)	Malaysia	Cryptic/rare taxa missed by visual surveys, reef stress and recovery indicators, juvenile reef fish	OBIS Malaysia // SEA OBIS
Iligan Bay and Camiguin Island	Philippines	Invasive and rare species, hidden biodiversity (giant clams, sea turtles, seahorses) in understudied seascapes	// SEA OBIS
Península Valdés	Argentina	High-resolution biodiversity baseline (microbes to megafauna), rare/cryptic/invasive species, climate-driven community shifts	// OBIS Argentina
Galápagos Marine Reserve	Ecuador	Biodiversity across coastal to deep-water ecosystems, invasive species and pathogen early detection, connectivity	// OBIS Ecuador, OBIS CPPS, ESP OBIS
Parque Nacional Huatulco	Mexico	Reef recovery after 2023-24 mass mortality, microbiome change during Oxygen Minimum Zone intrusions	// OBIS USA
Christmas Island and Cocos (Keeling) Islands Marine Parks	Australia	Species presence across reef to deep-slope habitats, community change, invasive species surveillance	// OBIS Australia, IndOBIS
Manyangue na Elombo-Campo Marine Park	Cameroon	Cetaceans incl. critically endangered Atlantic humpback dolphin, African manatee, ~40 shark and ray species	// AfrOBIS
Cananéia–Iguape–	Brazil	Baseline across mangrove/estuarine/coastal habitats, rare, cryptic and invasive species,	// OBIS Brazil

Peruibe EPA (CIP-EPA)		seasonal variation	
Motupore Island Research Centre (Bootless Bay)	Papua New Guinea	Baseline biodiversity, water and sediment quality trends for proposed Bootless Bay MPA	// SWP OBIS

2.1.6.2. Horizon Europe projects

2.1.6.2.1. MPA Europe

Silas Principe reported that the MPA Europe project was extended by three months (until 31 July 2026). In practice, all deliverables have been completed, but this extension allows us to make improvements to several of them. For OBIS specifically, it enables the inclusion of additional datasets in the OBIS network (D3.1), the publication of the paper documenting the Species Distribution Models (SDMs - currently under review at Scientific Data), the publication of the paper describing the tool developed for reviewing the SDMs (currently under consideration at Methods in Ecology and Evolution), and further improvements to the MPA Europe Atlas and Shiny application.

The main outcome of the project for the OBIS community has been the production of range maps for more than 12,000 marine species, including predictions under different climate scenarios at a fine spatial resolution of approximately 5 km. All models are openly available (<https://shiny.obis.org/distmaps/>), and the pipeline developed for their production (https://github.com/iobis/mpaeu_sdm and https://github.com/iobis/mpaeu_msdm) will support the development of the next generation of models, with the ultimate goal of extending this approach to the entire OBIS dataset. For OBIS nodes, this provides a valuable resource for local/regional analysis (e.g. providing list of potential species richness, potential for species invasion, potential biodiversity changes due to climate change). The range maps can also help to validate records (e.g. checking if a record for a particular species falls within suitable areas).

2.1.6.2.2. BioEcoOcean

Elizabeth Lawrence reported on BioEcoOcean which is in month 29 of 48. OBIS leads WP5 (Capacity development for integrated ocean observation) and contributes to WP2 (Blueprint for Integrated Ocean Science development) and WP4 (Blueprint Application & Testing: Demonstrating an operational workflow for BioEco EOV development), with minor involvement across all other work packages. Implementation is well on track for all deliverables and milestones. WP5 focuses on the development of training resources to support the implementation and dissemination of OCEANIS (formerly “the Blueprint”), a collaborative planning tool to support integrated ocean observation. This includes the OCEANIS Quick Start Guide (D5.1; first version: <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.18672397>) and a more comprehensive course (D5.2; currently being drafted).

In WP4, OBIS supports EOVS-related work, including the implementation of the EOVS Metadata Application connected to the GOOS BioEco Portal, and alignment of OBIS (meta)data standards with GOOS and OceanOPS (D4.2). WP4 supports EOVS data schema development, work that is also progressed through the OBIS DCG, deliverable D5.4. This work directly supports the OBIS community in submitting and managing EOVS-compliant data. The project will also produce datasets to be published to OBIS.

2.1.6.2.3. MARCO-BOLO

Stephen Formel reported on MARCO-BOLO. MARCO-BOLO is in month 43 of 48 and will come to an end on Nov 30, 2026. OBIS has a wide-ranging role, described in detail in the [Project Management Guide \(D7.1\)](#). OBIS co-leads WP6, the project's stakeholder engagement work and chairs its Community of Practice, while also contributing to the data management (WP1) and eDNA work (WP2). The involvement of OBIS in MARCO-BOLO strengthens the data flows, standards, and Essential Variable pipelines that feed marine biodiversity observations into OBIS, while connecting European observation efforts to the global system OBIS coordinates. For OBIS nodes, this means better-quality, more interoperable, and FAIR data reaching the network and tools for OBIS Nodes to better connect with ODIS.

MARCO-BOLO WP1, Co-led by Dan Lear, who also serves as the co-chair of the OBIS-SG, WP1 is tasked with co-developing and establishing robust and lasting specifications for biodiversity (meta)data exchange with European and global biodiversity systems, and developing a lightweight proof-of-concept implementations to validate their fitness for purpose. Two of three deliverables have been submitted and approved ([D1.1](#) ; [D1.2](#)). D1.3, a retrospective synthesis of the WP1 work, will be submitted to MARCO-BOLO project managers for review on 30 June 2026. The metadata catalogue tool for describing MARCO-BOLO products and demonstrating the proof-of-concept for a lightweight system is functional but remains in development. The main developer is Stephen Formel, from the OBIS Secretariat. The tool is described in GitHub: <https://github.com/marco-bolo/csv-to-json-ld> and here: <https://lab.marcobolo-project.eu/csv-to-json-ld/overview.html>

MARCO-BOLO WP2 was finalized in November 2025. OBIS contributed to a set of datasets and software/pipelines facilitating the implementation of eDNA-based monitoring (D2.2), a report on the congruence between traditional and eDNA-based biodiversity observations, and their robustness across bioinformatics issues and diversity metrics (D2.3), and a report on the definition of eDNA-based EBVs with associated eDNA-based EBV datasets and efficiency of eDNA for detecting/quantifying taxa/species of interest (D2.4) all delivered on the 31st of November 2025. Within this WP, OBIS co-led the MARCO-BOLO Data Analysis Challenge compiling biodiversity data results from two initial eDNA datasets analysed by a panel of bioinformatic pipelines from different participants. In total, 13 participants submitted a total of 15 output datasets for a 18S protist observatory dataset, and 25 participants submitted a total of 101 output dataset for a 12S, 16S and COI fish aquarium dataset. The full compilation of the output data is available on Zenodo ([10.5281/zenodo.17739995](https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.17739995)) and the project analyses are

ongoing on github (<https://github.com/marco-bolo/data-analysis-challenge>). The work done during this challenge is contributing to OBIS guidelines on DNA-derived data sharing (D5.5). The project supported the scientific officer Emilie Boulanger's participation to BioMonWeek 2026 where co-led a discussion table on DNA-derived data during the "Getting started with eDNA monitoring" workshop organised on the 5th of May, contributing towards OBIS Workplan D5.5.

MARCO-BOLO WP6, is co-led by Lisa Benedetti, OBIS Stakeholder Engagement Officer. Lisa also serves on the Project Implementation Committee. Dan Lear, OBIS-SG co-chair, is a contributor to this WP. Within WP6, Lisa is leading the coordination of a Community of Practice (CoP) for the project which includes key members of the marine observation monitoring community in the EU and internationally. The aim of the CoP is to ensure that project outputs are stakeholder driven. GOOS BioEco Panel member Lina Mtwana Nordlund is actively involved as a key member of the CoP. This work contributes to OBIS Objective IV. Empower communities through capacity development and collaboration. Lisa also contributed to the co-organization of the [EU BioMonWeek 2026](#) conference where MARCO-BOLO supported the participation of 4 OBIS Secretariat staff as well as the SG Co-chair. Two dedicated workshops on EOVS/EBVs were held at the conference and co-organized by the OBIS Secretariat: (1) Understanding EBVs and EOVS with GOOS BioEco Panel member Lina Mtwana Nordlund and (2) How to handle derived data products and outputs for EBVs and EOVS with Dan Lear, OBIS-SG co-chair. This work contributes towards OBIS workplan outcome WP1.1.2 - GOOS Biodiversity and Ecosystem Observation and data exchange. Altogether, two of four deliverables have been submitted and approved (D6.1 - sensitive/not open and [D6.2](#)) for WP6. The last two deliverables, which are focused on translating final project outputs into knowledge resources for targeted audiences (e.g., policy makers), D6.3 Knowledge Transfer resources tailored for the policy, industry, civil society and data/research stakeholder communities and D6.4 Report summarising Knowledge Transfer Activities, will be submitted later this year. Lisa is organizing the final stakeholder event for the project, which is being held 16 November 2026, back-to-back with the 7th World Conference on Marine Biodiversity (WCMB) in Bruges, Belgium.

2.1.6.2.4. eDNAqua-Plan

Emilie Boulanger reported that OBIS successfully co-led WP3 on Data Standards, Data Linking, & Compatibility by leading or supporting the delivery of the Report of best practices for reference databases including a set of machine-interpretable criteria to evaluate reliable references ([D3.1](#)), the Report of best practices for eDNA data repositories, including a model of metadata standards alignment ([D3.2](#)) and the Report presenting workflows and data storage/accessibility approaches used currently in DNA-based biodiversity monitoring ([D3.3](#)). OBIS also contributed to the Blueprint for future systems /workflow(s), delivered on the 1st of June 2026. The project is in its final months, ending in August 2026. A Roadmap for implementation of the optimal system(s) /workflow(s) is due on the 30th of June 2021, and the final event will be held at the European Parliament on the 1st of July 2026. Emilie Boulanger will attend the final event in Brussels as WP3 co-lead and member of the Project Implementation Committee.

2.1.6.2.5. DTO-BioFlow

Pieter Provoost reported on DTO-BioFlow. The project is in its final year. Within DTO-BioFlow Work Package 3, OBIS plays a central role in coordinating and delivering sustained marine biodiversity data flows into the Digital Twin Ocean. As lead of Task 3.5, together with partners OBIS is driving the integration of global biodiversity data and the development of new data pipelines from diverse sources, including citizen science, industrial, and literature-based datasets. It also contributes to genomic data workflows by supporting standards for eDNA and metabarcoding data ingestion.

Key achievements include the development of a combined OBIS/GBIF gridded species occurrence product aligned with WoRMS (*speciesgrids*, <https://github.com/iobis/speciesgrids>), and the creation of a GeoParquet version of the OBIS dataset, now available as part of the AWS Open Data program. Both products are in the final stages of being included in the European Digital Twin Ocean (EDITO). For the OBIS community, they provide cloud-optimized access to OBIS data and enable large-scale analyses. *speciesgrids* enables rapid mapping of marine species distributions, including data from GBIF.

2.1.6.3. MOZAIEK

Silas Principe reported on a new 3-year Flanders-funded (FUST) project that will commence in 2027: MOZAIEK (Modular Biodiversity Data Infrastructure for Ocean Applications, 2027–2029). MOZAIEK will deliver at least ten harmonised marine biodiversity data packages, each linked to a GOOS BioEco Essential Ocean Variable and produced at multiple processing levels. These packages will be generated through open, modular, and version-controlled processing pipelines that aggregate data from OBIS and GBIF, integrate environmental and satellite data where relevant, and apply quality control and taxonomic validation. Each package is accompanied by a gap analysis product that explicitly documents spatial, taxonomic, temporal, and methodological gaps in the underlying observations. All packages and pipelines will be DOI-citable and documented with training materials for different user groups. A co-designed demonstrator in the Caribbean Sea will validate the infrastructure in the context of marine heatwave impact assessment, providing a transferable model for other applications and regions. The total budget of the project is USD 1,589,804.

The project directly contributes to three OBIS Work Plan outcomes adopted at SG-OBIS-13. It provides the first large-scale set of EOVS-linked products for the operational Products Catalogue (Outcome 7), discoverable through ODIS. It fulfills the data product pilot for national policy (Outcome 8) by delivering standardised inputs for CBD KM-GBF indicators (Targets 20–21), BBNJ reporting, and the UN World Ocean Assessment. It also implements a systematic approach to quantify and monitor EOVS data coverage within OBIS, with gap analysis products accompanying each data package (Outcome 5).

MOZAIEK will bring multiple benefits to OBIS nodes. Every data package carries a full DOI provenance chain, so when users cite an OBIS data package, the originating datasets are cited automatically, increasing nodes' measurable scientific impact and visibility. The open pipelines and analysis-ready packages will be available for OBIS nodes to use in their own regional/local analyses and user requests, without duplicating effort and with increased efficiency. Each data package includes an explicit gap analysis that OBIS nodes can use to advocate for targeted monitoring investment in their region.

MOZAIEK advances all four OBIS strategic objectives: sustainable infrastructure, evidence-based policy, operational data services, and capacity development. It raises OBIS's profile in operational and policy communities through the marine heatwave demonstrator, supporting the goal of demonstrating real-world impact.

The EC-OBIS welcomed the progress reports and congratulated the OBIS Secretariat on securing FUST funding and looked forward to the results of the work to be carried out.

2.1.3 Communication

Laurent Chmiel, OBIS community engagement and communication officer reported on this agenda item. The draft OBIS Communication Plan 2026-2027² (established in January 2026, updated in April 2026) ensures the implementation of the draft OBIS Communication Strategy 2026-2027³ (established in December 2025, updated in January 2026), which supersedes the 2025 strategy⁴ and will be presented for adoption by the OBIS SG and guides the OBIS' outreach and communications actions. Both documents support the OBIS Workplan for 2026-2027.

The Implementation Roadmap of the OBIS Communication Plan (pages 5-23) details the state of play of the infrastructure's ongoing communication and outreach efforts. Q1 and Q2 of 2026 have already seen the launch of several important actions, such as the OBIS Node Spotlight articles (<https://obis.org/tag/node-spotlight/>), a redesigned version of the use-case page on the OBIS website, and a re-energized version of the OBIS Pulse newsletter. The creation of some assets has been slightly delayed due to their time-consuming production: creation of OBIS "wow-graphs", video assets, infographics, and longer articles. Their creation will be moved to 2026 Q3. This shift is purely internal and doesn't affect OBIS' communication capacity.

The OBIS website is undergoing new developments that will help improve the readability of the OBIS' value proposition, as well as highlight how OBIS supports the IOC's Member States, as well as the IOC's High-Level Objectives (HLOs) and Medium-Term Strategy. The ongoing overhaul of the use cases pages and a set of dedicated interactive pages will help create shareable, policy-facing content showcasing OBIS data, tools, and products. Content on the website, such as the OBIS Node Spotlight articles, helps make the OBIS Community more

² <https://oceanexpert.org/document/38554>

³ <https://oceanexpert.org/document/38555>

⁴ <https://oceanexpert.org/document/36972>

visible. The OBIS newsletter, paused due to a sending client account change, is also undergoing a redesign.

Community-specific communication efforts directly stemming from the OBIS Work Plan for 2026-2027 are underway, with diverse outcomes. The redesign of the OBIS Pulse newsletter, including its sending process (timed batches, renewed headline to deter spam filters), has seen an increase in openings by 5% to reach 46,5%, with a click rate of 14%. The OBIS pulse newsletter, targeting members of OBIS Nodes, currently serves 111 recipients. The stakeholder mapping exercise is underway, with the first iteration of the communication building blocks scheduled for mid-August.

On social media channels, after a short-phased revitalization of the OBIS Instagram (OBIS Marine Species Splash and OBIS Data Superpowers), focus has shifted to LinkedIn and Bluesky only (see *infra*). LinkedIn remains OBIS' strongest communication and outreach channel in terms of followers (close to 6,000) but also, and more importantly, in terms of engagement. Between 1 July 2025 and 9 June 2026, the channel has generated 186,090 impressions, 3,496 reactions, 112 comments, and 87 reposts, leading to 2,788 page views. These numbers are encouraging and should be improved, with better ways to engage and interact with the audience. The success of the eDNA Expeditions posts demonstrates the potential for progress. Bluesky remains underexploited, with 216 followers and very little interaction.

In December 2025, a new modular visual identity system was developed for OBIS, including the possibility to create logos for the Nodes, badges, and more. This project was stopped due to the announcement of the new IOC Communication Strategy 2026-2030⁵ which will be presented at the 59th IOC Executive Council June 2026 and might remain stalled until the new IOC visual identity is finalized and adopted by the 34th IOC Assembly in June 2027.

The OBIS Communication Strategy and the OBIS Communication Plan have been updated to ensure OBIS provides the best possible operational support to the implementation of the new IOC Communication Strategy. While the OBIS Secretariat fully supports the need for brand unification and stronger perception that OBIS is part of IOC encompassed in the proposed IOC Communication Strategy. However, it is also important to maintain the voice and visibility of the OBIS community on the global biodiversity data stage and ensure the continuity and stability of the infrastructure's presence. A series of communication-related pledges as part of the IOC communication and brand guidelines to be developed and presented at the IOC assembly in 2027 have been shared with the IOC Management Team. These adjustments include maintaining the integrity of the OBIS website structure and content, creating a combined IOC-OBIS logo to be used on all OBIS communication assets, and maintaining two communication channels—LinkedIn and Bluesky—as well as community-relevant hashtags. Two proposals were accepted by IOC management on 13 May 2026, on a temporary basis: the combined IOC-OBIS logo proposition, as well as maintaining the OBIS LinkedIn channel while exploring ways to better link the OBIS LinkedIn page to the IOC page. The two remaining requested proposals

⁵ <https://oceanexpert.org/document/38353>

(keep the OBIS website and URL and Bluesky) are still pending, and their status should be addressed in a timely manner.

The EC-OBIS welcomed the report on the status of the Communication Plan and underlined the strategic importance of communication for the continued relevance and impact of OBIS. The EC-OBIS emphasized that the OBIS brand - built over 26 years of community-driven work - is a recognized, trusted and respected asset across the global biodiversity data community, with a reach that extends beyond marine science into the science-to-policy interfaces of the IOC Member States and multilateral processes such as the CBD and BBNJ. Preserving the visibility and integrity of this brand is crucial for OBIS to continue mobilizing data contributors, retaining Node engagement, and delivering on its mandate. In this respect, the EC-OBIS stressed that sustained and explicit support from the IOC is essential. As a core programme component of the IODE programme within IOC, OBIS operates at the intersection of science, data and policy, and must be able to communicate with a specific technical and scientific audience: data providers, Nodes, NODCs and ADUs, marine biodiversity scientists, and biodiversity policy users. The information needs and engagement modes of these stakeholders differ from those addressed by the central IOC channels. The EC-OBIS therefore welcomed the two proposals accepted on a temporary basis on 13 May 2026 (the combined IOC–OBIS logo and the maintenance of the OBIS LinkedIn channel) as a first step to preserve OBIS visibility and capacity to communicate and engage specifically with its audiences.

The EC-OBIS expressed its expectation that the two temporary accepted proposals, as well as the remaining requests—the preservation of the OBIS website and URL, and continuation of the Bluesky channel—will be addressed in a timely manner, through a collaborative and consultative process with the OBIS leadership via the IODE Steering Group for OBIS, and well ahead of the finalization of the new IOC visual identity at the 34th IOC Assembly in June 2027. The EC-OBIS further encouraged the OBIS Secretariat to continue engaging constructively with the IOC Central Communications Team to ensure that the OBIS Communication Strategy and Plan operate fully in support of, and within, the new IOC Communication Strategy.

2.2. Progress report Nodes Coordination Group

Maria Cornthwaite and John Nicholls, as Co-Chairs of the OBIS Nodes Coordination Group, introduced this agenda item and presented a report on the activities of the Coordination Group.

The OBIS NCG is an important component of the OBIS community-led governance system. The NCG is the main platform for OBIS Node managers and Nodes representatives to actively collaborate, through discussions, exchanges, and actions.

The OBIS NCG is in charge of the OBIS Workplan:

- Outcome 1 "Ensure an operational OBIS Nodes Coordination Group (NCG)",
- Outcome 2 "Create and adopt communication tools to leverage the visibility of the Nodes and their contributions", and
- Outcome 3 "Improve and track capacity among OBIS Nodes".

These outcomes are essential to ensure cohesion among the OBIS Nodes, encourage collaboration, and maintain capacity. To avoid overburdening the Nodes, most of the actions under Outcomes 1 to 3 were built in consultation with NCG members whenever possible and proposed as feedback-ready prototypes. As of today, the NCG has achieved one KPI, is well underway to achieve 6 KPIs, and has completed 4 deliverables. Four KPIs have not yet been addressed, while one deliverable has not been started.

Progress related to OBIS outcome 1. Ensure an operational OBIS Nodes Coordination Group (NCG)

Improve communication and promote exchanges between OBIS Nodes, and between the OBIS Nodes and the Secretariat.

- **KPI 1.1: At least five online dual-session meetings scheduled through October 2026**

This KPI will be met at the NCG meeting #12 taking place on 20 August 2026.

- **KPI 1.2: Number of OBIS Nodes participating per meeting, with a minimum of 10**

Across 4 meetings and 8 sessions, average attendance is 12 distinct Nodes per session (sessions 1 and 2 mixed), with co-chairs counted under their home Nodes. This number could be improved with increased pre-meeting engagement, such as sending personalized reminders on preferred channels (WhatsApp, email, Slack, etc.).

- **KPI 1.3: High percentage of OBIS Nodes actively presenting or leading discussions during NCG meetings, with a target of 60 per cent per year**

The average mic-share time per NCG meeting is:

- NCG Co-chairs: 23 %
- SG and CG Co-Chairs: 24%
- Nodes: 25%
- Secretariat: 28%

If we consider that all Co-Chairs are part of a Node, the Node / Secretariat balance is 72% / 28%. The NCG Co-Chairs have introduced at meeting #8 a new meeting structure making more space for inter-Node discussion. This structure could be further improved by collecting discussion topics directly from each Node two weeks ahead of an NCG meeting and entirely building the meeting on the proposed content. This collection could happen by email or through other channels, such as the OBIS Discourse. Discussions or topics that would not make the cut could be moved asynchronously on Discourse.

- **KPI 1.4: Number of reported inter-Node collaborations not covered by the Node-to-Node programme, supported or initiated by the NCG, with a target of 10 per year**

This KPI remains very low and will most likely not be met by October 2026. To date, two inter-Node collaborations took place: a collaboration between OBIS OPI and OBIS Australia on archeological marine biodiversity data, and a collaboration between AfrOBIS and OBIS Kenya on establishing a common proposal to answer a GBIF BID call supported by the OBIS Secretariat. The Secretariat and the NCG are working on a third collaboration between OBIS OPI and OBIS Panamá.

- **KPI 1.5: High percentage of OBIS Node satisfaction with communication and support from the NCG, with a target of 80 per cent per year**

This KPI will only be measured later this year.

- **Deliverable 1.1: Meeting minutes shared through a public portal via the OBIS website.**

This deliverable will be completed within the coming weeks.

- **Deliverable 1.2: A revised version of the NCG meeting to give more space to Node-to-Node communication (standing deliverable).**

The NCG Admins are constantly working on improving the format of the meetings, including by providing new engagement means before the meetings (see above, KPI 1.2)

- **Deliverable 1.3: An improved OBIS Pulse newsletter to help circulate information horizontally among Nodes.**

The NCG Admins are constantly improving the newsletter design and content, based on feedback provided by Node members.

Progress related to OBIS Outcome 2. Create and adopt communication tools to leverage the visibility of the Nodes and their contributions

- **KPI 2.1: Number of OBIS Nodes using and adapting the communication toolkit to reach their institutions and funders, with a target of 50 per cent of the OBIS Nodes.**

This KPI will be measured later this year.

- **KPI 2.2: High satisfaction with the development of communication kits that fit the needs of OBIS Nodes, with reported Node satisfaction of 80 per cent as reported in the annual OBIS Nodes engagement survey.**

This KPI will be measured later this year.

- **Deliverable 2.1: Create a building block-based communication toolkit aimed at funders, backers, and host organizations, that can be adapted to each OBIS Node.**

This deliverable is ongoing. A stakeholder mapping exercise has been initiated by the NCG to better understand the institutional context surrounding the OBIS Nodes. This stakeholder exercise is a prelude to the creation of the block-based communication toolkit. The stakeholder mapping exercise ends by 15 June 2026, and the first draft for the block-based communication toolkits will be released by mid-August 2026.

Progress related to OBIS outcome 3. Improve and track capacity among OBIS Nodes

- **KPI 3.1: Number of reported Node-to-Node mentoring activities established annually, with a target of 10**

Since most of OTTER, the Node-to-Node support programme was moved to the OBIS Discourse, this KPI would benefit from a clarification: if “activity” means “interaction between Nodes on a technical question, with one Node representative providing an answer to a question asked by another Node”, then this KPI will most likely be met at the time of SG-OBIS-14.

- **KPI 3.2: Number of FAQ entries, with a target of 20**

This KPI will be achieved within the coming weeks. A prototype of the OBIS Knowledge Base, including a discussion-capture process, has been created and content will be filled out soon.

- **KPI 3.3: Number of OBIS Nodes who report having filled capacity gaps in the last year through NCG-led actions, with a target of 6**

This KPI has not been met yet

- **Deliverable 3.1: Create an onboarding roadmap and process for new OBIS Nodes, in association with the OBIS Secretariat and the OBIS Nodes.**

This KPI will be achieved within the coming weeks. A draft roadmap has been created. Its content is currently under review by some members of the OBIS Secretariat and the NCG Admins. It will be first shared with the SG Co-Chairs and other CG Co-Chairs before being more widely circulated among OBIS Nodes Managers for comments. The roadmap will be published on the OBIS website.

- **Deliverable 3.2: Set up the Node-to-Node programme, in association with the OBIS Secretariat and the OBIS Nodes.**

OTTER, the OBIS Node-to-Node support programme framework, was launched in February 2026. It is based on the OBIS Discourse platform and originally consisted of a dedicated section where Nodes could exchange on technical or administrative issues. As the entire Discourse has been made private and accessible to the OBIS Nodes only, including message consultation, the OTTER section has been made redundant and could probably be removed. The OBIS Discourse in its entirety should be considered as the main Node-to-Node support programme platform.

- **Deliverable 3.3: Create a process to capture essential capacity-related discussions across communication channels and save them to a FAQ.**

This deliverable is well underway. A discussion-capture process mixing human collection and AI-supported editing is being finalized and should be implemented within the coming weeks. The process consists of 5 steps: human curation of relevant topics on the main OBIS support channels (GitHub, Slack, Helpdesk, Discourse), AI-edition of the collected discussion, including anonymization of the original asker, AI-formatting of the discussion into .md templates, human proofreading and validation, human publication to the Knowledge Base.

- **Deliverable 3.4: Create a central Node Knowledge Repository on the OBIS website to document processes, tools, and skills available for each Node. The Repository will be co-designed with the OBIS Nodes.**

This deliverable has not been started.

Challenges and Required Changes

Despite the implemented changes, the current NCG meetings are still very much top-down: the agenda is created by the NCG admins, and discussion, even outside the agenda, is often initiated by the same NCG admins. A new way forward could be to open the NCG meeting agenda two weeks in advance and gather suggestions from Nodes members for topics to discuss, alongside items proposed by the NCG Admins. This could be a way to promote horizontal discussions: topics brought by the Nodes are discussed by the Nodes. Updates from the SG and the Secretariat could be given at the same time, and Nodes could decide to lift some of the updates during the meeting or ask for more details to be discussed. Finally, on the model of the Flash Talks, Nodes could be encouraged to share a recent success story or a

recent achievement. Beyond the celebratory moment, these presentations could inspire other Nodes and foster horizontal connections.

The share of actual mic-time from the Nodes could be increased. The 72%-28% speaking time ratio between the Nodes and the Secretariat includes SG and CG Co-Chairs' speaking time and might hide that a few Nodes are holding the microphone, while most stay silent: The top 4 Nodes hold the floor 50% of all Node talk-time; and the top 8 Nodes hold 80%. These numbers include Co-Chairs: Of the 318 minutes of "Node" talk-time across 8 sessions, 62% comes from Co-Chairs and only 28% from all other Nodes combined.

Targeted outreach ahead of each NCG meeting towards the 8 Nodes who haven't attended one of the eight sessions between December 2025 and June 2026 could help increase engagement.

OTTER, as well as Node-to-Node collaborations outside of that framework, remain a challenge for the NCG. Some actions, such as making the OBIS Discourse private and creating connection opportunities for the Nodes to log onto the platform might help drive uptake. The programme has only been in place for less than five months: assessing its success or failure at that time might be premature.

Finally, the lack of funding to support Node-related activities is another challenge that should be addressed. It creates a risk of imbalance where less financially able Nodes would be excluded from in-person meetings, pushing them to the edges of the community.

Future Workplan Considerations

Future workplan considerations could include strengthening Secretariat support, with an additional role that would allow for better engagement of the NCG with each Node. This engagement could be targeting, in priority, the least active Nodes and try to get them up to speed.

Additional dedicated NCG Admin working sessions between meetings would also help create more momentum, as well as opening the production of deliverables to the Nodes, using a similar model as the EU Work Packages. Deliverables would still be under the responsibility of the NCG, and Node participation would be voluntary, with involvement depending on available resources and time. We could use a time-boxed task model, with small working groups collaborating on components of a deliverable.

The EC-OBIS acknowledged the need for additional capacity to support the OBIS Nodes and to deepen engagement in the Nodes Coordination Group (NCG), and welcomed the plan to hire and share a part-time helpdesk support officer with ODIS under the IODE Regular Programme.

2.3. Progress report OBIS Data Coordination Group

Mr Ruben Perez and Mr Victor Chocho, as OBIS DCG Co-Chairs, introduced this agenda item and presented a report on the activities of the DCG.

The membership of the DCG is currently: <https://oceanexpert.org/group/538>

The OBIS DCG contributes primarily to OBIS Workplan Outcome 4, “Ensure an operational Data Coordination Group”, and Outcome 5, “Review and support the alignment and adoption of data standards, specifications, and publication mechanisms”.

Overall, the 2026 DCG workplan is progressing through a sub-group model, with individual deliverables advanced by smaller groups made of OBIS Sec and volunteer OBIS members and reporting back to the wider DCG for review, feedback and endorsement. This approach has helped maintain progress across several technical areas while keeping the DCG as a coordination and alignment forum.

Progress related to OBIS outcome 4 “Ensure an operational Data Coordination Group”:

- **Deliverable 4.1: Meeting minutes shared through a public portal via the OBIS website.**

Progress on this deliverable continues advancing. The DCG has discussed and agreed on the preferred approach for making its activities more visible: publishing in the coordination groups page the curated, high-level summaries of progress, decisions and outputs rather than full internal minutes. This approach supports transparency while recognising that not all internal discussion is appropriate for public release.

- **Deliverable 4.2: Share within the DCG the list of prioritised activities for bi-monthly review and endorsement.**

There has not been a formal bi-monthly prioritization of the group tasks given the current workload and the voluntary nature of the group. However, new tasks have been brought to the group in an ad-hoc manner. The topics raised were data citation and AI usage, Darwin Core Data Package usage guidance, obistools maintenance, and coordination with GBIF regional nodes. However, these are not currently treated as core workplan priorities unless they are directly connected to an agreed deliverable. The DCG may continue to monitor such topics, but substantive work on them would require explicit inclusion in future deliverables.

Progress related to OBIS outcome 5 “Review and support the alignment and adoption of data standards, specifications, and publication mechanisms”

- **Deliverable 5.1: Deliver two workshops to advance adoption of data standards within OBIS.**

Two workshops to advance adoption of data standards within OBIS are on track. The first workshop, focused on eDNA data, has been scheduled for 2 July 2026, with reusable training materials being developed and hosted on GitHub. A second workshop on Darwin Core Data Package is planned for later in 2026, in collaboration with GBIF, with a focus on introducing the data package structure and its relevance for OBIS workflows.

- **Deliverable 5.2: Document a plan to support the WoRMS Data Management Team in OBIS taxon annotation improvements.**

The plan has been drafted and is under review. It proposes using trained expert reviewers to validate automated annotations, with support from the WoRMS team for reviewer training. Implementation has been delayed by staffing changes. The launch of the training and work to review the annotations is anticipated to start towards the end of Q3 2026.

- **Deliverable 5.3: Document a DwC-DP indexing strategy in collaboration with GBIF.**

The deliverable has slightly shifted, while remaining aligned with its original direction. A new OBIS indexing pipeline version has been completed, which was a prerequisite for implementing Darwin Core Data Package support later in the year. This update also enabled OBIS to index large eDNA datasets. The core remaining task is to develop the concrete DwC-DP indexing plan in collaboration with GBIF.

- **Deliverable 5.4: Design and document an approach, implementation plan, and timeline to quantify and monitor EOVS data within OBIS.**

This deliverable is on track. A [draft EOVS monitoring plan](#) has been prepared, proposing dataset-level EOVS tagging through the OBIS pipeline. Initial tests focus on Seagrass and Marine Mammals. The approach combines taxonomy- and measurement-based criteria, AI-assisted mapping of EOVS specification sheets to Darwin Core, manual quality control, and transformation into machine-readable formats such as LinkML. An EOVS Spec Sheet Transformation Guide ([first draft](#)) and pilot code are being developed in the OBIS EOVS data management GitHub repository (<https://github.com/iobis/eov-data-management>).

- **Deliverable 5.5: Review OBIS guidelines on eDNA data, and plan and document training that will improve knowledge and eDNA data delivery within the OBIS network.**

The OBIS eDNA guidance and the planning of training to improve eDNA data delivery are also progressing. A first structure for eDNA training modules has been prepared, and the group has discussed data quality control, replicates, case studies and the need to make guidance more modular and accessible. This work is closely linked to the July eDNA workshop (D5.1) and to the broader need for capacity development as new data types and technologies become more prominent in the OBIS network.

Challenges and Required Changes

The main operational challenge is the current low capacity to implement the workplan. The OBIS DCG depends on voluntary technical and scientific contributions from its community members. This makes prioritisation essential: the group cannot address every relevant topic within its broad scope unless it is linked to a formal deliverable.

No major change to the overall direction of the 2026-2027 workplan is proposed. However, some deliverables should be understood as multi-year activities. This is particularly the case for Darwin Core Data Package implementation, EOVS monitoring, taxon annotation review workflows, and eDNA guidance.

Future Workplan Considerations

For 2027, the DCG suggests focusing on consolidation and implementation of the work initiated in 2026. Proposed priorities include:

- Implementing and testing Darwin Core Data Package workflows in OBIS;
- Continuing capacity development through reusable training materials, case studies and updated guidance;
- Advancing the EOVS monitoring workflow from pilot mappings toward operational testing;
- Piloting the taxon annotation review process with trained expert reviewers;

For 2028-2029, the DCG suggests moving from pilot work and documentation toward operationalisation. Longer-term priorities could include:

- Integrating Darwin Core Data Package more fully into OBIS data publication and indexing workflows;
- Supporting Nodes and publishers in adopting event-based and data-package-based publication models;
- Establishing a sustained EOVS monitoring workflow within OBIS for all GOOS BioEco EOVS;
- Maintaining modular training and guidance for emerging data types;

Given the voluntary nature of the DCG, future workplans should remain focused and deliverable driven. Areas under the DCG's scientific and technical scope should only become active priorities when they are explicitly included in agreed deliverables, assigned to a responsible sub-group if appropriate, and supported by available member capacity.

The EC-OBIS welcomed the progress achieved by the DCG while acknowledging the challenges inherent in its voluntary structure and the absence of dedicated Secretariat support resulting from the unfilled OBIS technical position. The EC-OBIS encouraged broader participation and engagement from across the OBIS node network, noting that

the issues addressed by the DCG are central to the successful implementation of OBIS and have implications for all nodes.

2.4. Progress report OBIS Products Coordination Group

Mr Jonathan Pye and Dr Stephen Formel⁶, as OBIS PCG Co-Chairs, introduced this agenda item and presented a report on the activities of the PCG. The membership of the PCG is currently: <https://oceanexpert.org/group/503>

The OBIS PCG contributes primarily to OBIS Workplan Outcome 6, 7 and 8.

Progress related to OBIS outcome 6 “Ensure an Operational Products Coordination Group (PCG)”

Outcome 6 has been achieved with some notes below on possible improvements for future workplans.

- **KPI 6.1: At least 5 dual online sessions scheduled through October 2026.**

Met. Six dual online sessions scheduled (0700 & 1400 UTC, second Monday monthly): Complete: Dec 8, Feb 9, Apr 13, Jun 8. Remaining: Aug 10 and Oct 12

- **D6.1: Meeting minutes shared through a public portal in collaboration with the other Coordination Groups.**

In progress - in consultation with other CGs; annual running notes consolidated into a single google doc. Public sharing of minutes is still under discussion across the CGs.

Progress related to OBIS outcome 7 “Robust operational deployment of the OBIS Products Catalogue”

Deployment and feedback machinery (D7.1, D7.3) are progressing well; the policy-indicator strand (KPI 1, D7.2, and half of D7.4) in progress as linkages between Outcome 7 and 8.

- **KPI 7.1: Indicators for international efforts aligned with OBIS priorities are available for application to registered Products in the OBIS Products Catalogue.**

In progress

⁶ Dr Formel was OBIS-USA node manager when he committed to the two-year co-chair term in October 2024. He began working as a consultant with the Secretariat in May 2025.

- **KPI 7.2: Data products created by OBIS Secretariat as well as OBIS Nodes are registered in the OBIS Products Catalogue.**

In progress

- **KPI 7.3: Products from the OBIS Products Catalogue are available for harvest by ODIS.**

In progress. The Product Catalog exposes schema.org JSON-LD but isn't yet linked live to ODIS. Dependent on upcoming renovations to ODIS.

- **D7.1: OBIS Product Catalogue is officially deployed with OBIS styling and is integrated into the OBIS domain as part of the operational OBIS ecosystem.**

Technically met, but recent aesthetic updates need to be pushed from development to production and database cleaned to only include approved products.

- **D7.2: OBIS Products Catalogue schema extension for data product indicators meeting international policy outcomes (e.g., KM-GBF, CBD, WOA), in collaboration with partners and partner networks.**

Not yet started.

- **D7.3: Active GitHub repository for monitoring and incorporating feedback from OBIS nodes on appropriate language and nomenclature for metadata.**

Met - <https://github.com/iobis/obis-products-catalog/issues>

- **D7.4: Training material describing how OBIS uses the OBIS Products Catalogue, and indicating which data products should carry international policy indicators.**

In progress. Docs are fully available (<https://products.obis.org/docs/>) but training-specific materials are light.

Progress related to OBIS outcome 8 “Data product pilot showcasing OBIS' ability to serve national policy outcomes and highlight the richness of available data in OBIS's national and regional Nodes”

- **KPI 1: Data products expressing species richness or species-specific distribution models are available for OBIS nodes and regions to implement.**

In progress.

- **D8.1: Develop a set of data products focused on serving national policy outcomes as an example of OBIS' suitability in informing national-scale biodiversity strategies.**

In progress.

Challenges and Required Changes

Outcome N° 6: Coordination of organizational tools remains a small challenge; more of an annoyance than an inhibitor of work. The OceanExpert group, the PCG mailing list and Zoom meetings cannot be seamlessly connected. If live links can be created relying on a single source of truth for group members, it would reduce the time needed to organize the meetings.

Outcome N° 7: Customizing CKAN has been challenging and building a functional system with a robust developmental workflow took more time than expected.

Outcome N° 8: Limited time and capacity. We recently identified CBD GBF reporting as a tractable piece to deliver in the next six months.

Future Workplan Considerations

Outcome N° 6: Co-chairs have found that regularly scheduled planning meetings between each PCG meeting are very useful for staying organized and recommend updating the ToR to include this responsibility in descriptions of the co-chair position.

Outcome N° 7: Build harvest pathways for mature nodes: a needs assessment plus an ODIS-style direct-harvest option so nodes with their own catalogues aren't forced through the Zenodo-centric model.

Outcome N° 8: Depends on conversation over next 6 months.

New Tasks identified

obistools / pyobistools maintenance. The R package needs work (installability on current R, defined scope, governance); confirmed not abandoned, volunteers forming (Tom Webb, Jon Pye, Eduardo, Sachit) with intent to align with the pyobistools team (Jon Pye, Simon Beauvillier @ CIOOS). Candidate to propose formally at SG-14.

The EC-OBIS welcomed the progress made by the PCG and recognised that the MOZAIEK project, to be funded under FUST, will offer substantial support for the continued development of PCG activities.

3. Planning for OBIS workplan and budget 2027 and 2028-2029

Ward Appeltans introduced this agenda item. To prepare for the planning of the next OBIS work plan and budget, and to ensure that OBIS contributes to the overall IOC framework and priorities identified by the IOC Member States, we need to take the following into account: (i) UNESCO-IOC Results Framework, (ii) the IOC Medium-Term Strategy, (iii) IODE work plan, (iv) IOC Priority Areas Africa and SIDS, (v) the GOOS Biodiversity Plan, (vi) the IOC 2028-2029 work plan, and of course (vii) our own OBIS Strategic Objectives.

3.1. UNESCO-IOC Results Framework 43C/5

Output PI: Number of Member States routinely collecting and managing FAIR EOVS data on biodiversity and ecosystems through GOOS, ODIS and OBIS

Description:

This indicator tracks how many Member States are supported in routinely collecting and managing FAIR Essential Ocean Variable (EOV) data on biodiversity and ecosystems through the Global Ocean Observing System (GOOS) co-sponsored and led by IOC, and the IOC Ocean Data Information System (ODIS) and Ocean Biodiversity Information System (OBIS). Progress is tracked by the increase in the number of countries with OBIS nodes, which demonstrate routine ability to handle Member State's EOVS data in line with international and FAIR standards. Routine collection and management (strengthened through OBIS training and technical assistance and coordination with GOOS biological and ecological EOVS observing communities) ensures data quality and standardization for integration into the IOC data ecosystem. OBIS itself is a node of the IOC Ocean Data and Information System (ODIS). Increased support for OBIS nodes directly enhances interoperability and visibility of biodiversity and ecosystem EOVS data. This helps nations streamline observing and data practices, create sustained data flows, improve marine resource management, and meet reporting needs under multilateral environmental agreements and national obligations. Thus the indicator shows the IOCs effectiveness in building equitable capacity for Member States to sustainably collect, manage, publish, access, and use marine biodiversity EOVS data.

KPIs

- 2025: 27 countries (3 Africa, 1 SIDS)
- 2026: 29 countries (3 Africa, 2 SIDS)
- 2027: 31 countries (4 Africa, 2 SIDS)
- 2028: 33 countries (4 Africa, 3 SIDS)
- 2029: 35 countries (5 Africa, 5 SIDS)

This Output and KPI is one of the 4 that IOC reports to UNESCO.

3.2. IOC Medium-Term Strategy and 2026-2027 secretariat implementation plan

IOC High-Level Objective 1. Healthy ocean and sustained ocean ecosystem services

- **IOC Sub-Objective 1.1 Enhanced observations and data for increased understanding of ocean vulnerability to multiple stressors**
 - **KPI: Number of Member States routinely collecting and managing FAIR EOVS data on biodiversity and ecosystems through GOOS, ODIS and OBIS**

Note that this KPI is the same as the UNESCO 43C/5 output.

To implement IOC Sub-Objective 1.1, the IOC secretariat has 3 Work Packages of which 2 involve OBIS.

WP1.1.1 — IOC-wide framework for a digital ecosystem

This work package focuses on strengthening IOC data and information systems and services that enable Member States to generate, exchange and access high-quality, interoperable and FAIR ocean data. Key elements include the development and delivery of an IOC-wide operational data architecture, with improved metadata and data ingestion workflows, and the mapping and design of the next-generation ocean data information system. It also enables strengthening automated country-level reporting through strengthening the IOC Ocean Expert system. Collectively, this package ensures that Essential Ocean Variables (EOVs) (across HLOs 1-3) flow reliably into global systems, and that Member States – especially in Africa and SIDS – have a dependable data backbone to underpin assessment, planning and forecasting.

Key Deliverables:

- Concept for an IOC-wide data architecture framework that meets Member States needs
- FAIR data charter for MS and strengthened NODC engagement
- Improved OceanExpert technical and front-end development

WP1.1.2 — GOOS Biodiversity and Ecosystem Observation and data exchange

This work package [verb missing] global and regional ecosystem and biodiversity observing under GOOS. It supports Member States to enable and evolve an integrated and fit-for-purpose framework for global ocean observing that meets national, regional and global needs for marine biodiversity information. This work package also supports OBIS providing sustained data flows, and delivery of the Biology and Ecosystems Essential Ocean Variables (EOVs), and the expansion of the OBIS network, improving provenance and tagging practices, and offering standards, specifications and helpdesk support.

Key Deliverables:

- Expansion of OBIS network (Nodes & Institutions) (target: increase of 4 nodes of which 1 Africa and 1 SIDS)
- Increased number of datasets in OBIS (target: increase of 700 by 2027)
- GOOS Biodiversity Plan

3.3. IODE Work Plan

The IODE MG met in January 2026 and has set some priorities for IODE at two levels:

Six key priority areas for the 2026–2027 IODE workplan:

- Overarching/governance issues: IOC governance alignment, IODE restructuring, streamlining working groups, communications, staffing/recruitment, travel, and OceanExpert.
- IOC Data Architecture, NODC/ADU engagement, and ODIS: developing the Data Architecture implementation plan and a FAIR Data Charter (with GOOS), supporting the newly reconstituted ODIS Steering Group.
- OBIS: sustaining the marine biodiversity data infrastructure via its eight-outcome workplan.
- Programme Activities: particularly the World Ocean Database (WOD), which was flagged as very high risk; IODE support through data standardisation and quality control.
- Intersessional Working Group on Advanced Data Sharing in National Jurisdiction (ISWG-NJ); implementing Decision IOC-A-33/3.4.2.
- Capacity Development: OTGA as cornerstone, updating the QMF course (English/Spanish), coordinating training demand across IOC sections.

Longer-term "core focus" toward 2030:

- Strengthen and grow NODCs/ADUs (especially in the global South);
- provide a framework for data exchange in close collaboration with GOOS through the IOC Data Architecture; ensure FAIR and interoperable data; and
- streamline IODE communications/branding under a clear IOC identity.

Cross-cutting constraints and key recommendations:

- All activities must align with the IOC Medium-Term Strategy's five high-level objectives and be prioritised against a sharply reduced budget. IODE-29 will be held virtually in October 2026, and a draft 2027–2029 (and 2028–2029) workplan is to be prepared for the next Committee meeting. A recurring concrete KPI suggestion was raising the share of NODCs achieving QMF accreditation.

3.4. IOC Priority Areas: Africa and SIDS

The IODE Management Group at its last meeting (January 2026) has identified several priorities of relevance to Africa of which supporting, strengthening and growing NODCs and ADUs - including reactivating the ODINAFRICA network is directly relevant for OBIS. A dedicated IOCAFRICA–IODE data-exchange initiative is being developed to take this forward, with a workshop under consideration (work in progress).

In this context, the OBIS secretariat in consultation with the IOCAFRICA secretariat is proposing the following initiative, “Mobilizing the IOC ecosystem to advance Africa’s leadership in global marine biodiversity data”, which sets out a co-designed framework to increase African contributions to OBIS in support of national biodiversity reporting and the Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework. This could be anchored into the newly established IOCAFRICA Working Group on Data and Information Management (IOCAFRICA-ODIN) as an OBIS Africa Task Force operating under that Working Group, chaired and co-chaired by the two active African OBIS Nodes - AfrOBIS (South Africa) and OBIS Kenya - with secretariat support from the OBIS Secretariat and IOCAFRICA.

The OBIS Africa Task Force would pursue four strategic axes:

- Expanding its representativeness and reach among Member States;
- Exploring and supporting the establishment of new African OBIS Nodes, beginning with countries that already host an NODC;
- Organizing targeted data-mobilization workshops in Kenya and South Africa; and
- Developing a train-the-trainer programme for OBIS contribution, delivered with the OceanTeacher Global Academy (OTGA) and leading to IOC-recognized certification.

The initiative contributes directly to the IOC Results Framework under the High-Level Objective “Healthy Ocean and Sustained Ocean Ecosystem Services” - notably the expansion of the OBIS network and the increased availability of African biodiversity datasets.

IOCAfrica-9 is meeting today and is requested to endorse the creation of an OBIS Africa Task Force under the IOCAFRICA Working Group on Data and Information Management, with the governance arrangement and four strategic axes outlined above and could request the Secretariat (IOCAFRICA, with IODE and the OBIS Secretariat) to develop a workplan, deliverables and key performance indicators, and to pursue in-kind and extrabudgetary resources to support implementation and invite Member States to nominate representatives to the Working Group’s OBIS Task Force, and to support their participation;

3.5. OBIS Strategic Objectives

The SG-OBIS-13 (2025) adopted a new vision, mission and 4 strategic objectives for OBIS: <https://obis.org/about/visionmission/>, which align with the OBIS structure of coordination groups which support the implementation of the work plan and achieve the OBIS vision, mission and objectives. Any new work plan should be aligned with this framework.

3.6. GOOS Biodiversity Strategy 2026-2035

GOOS SC-15 (25 - 27 March 2026) adopted the GOOS Biodiversity Strategy 2026-2035⁷. The draft plan was presented at the SG-OBIS-13 in October 2025 and the OBIS Steering Group:

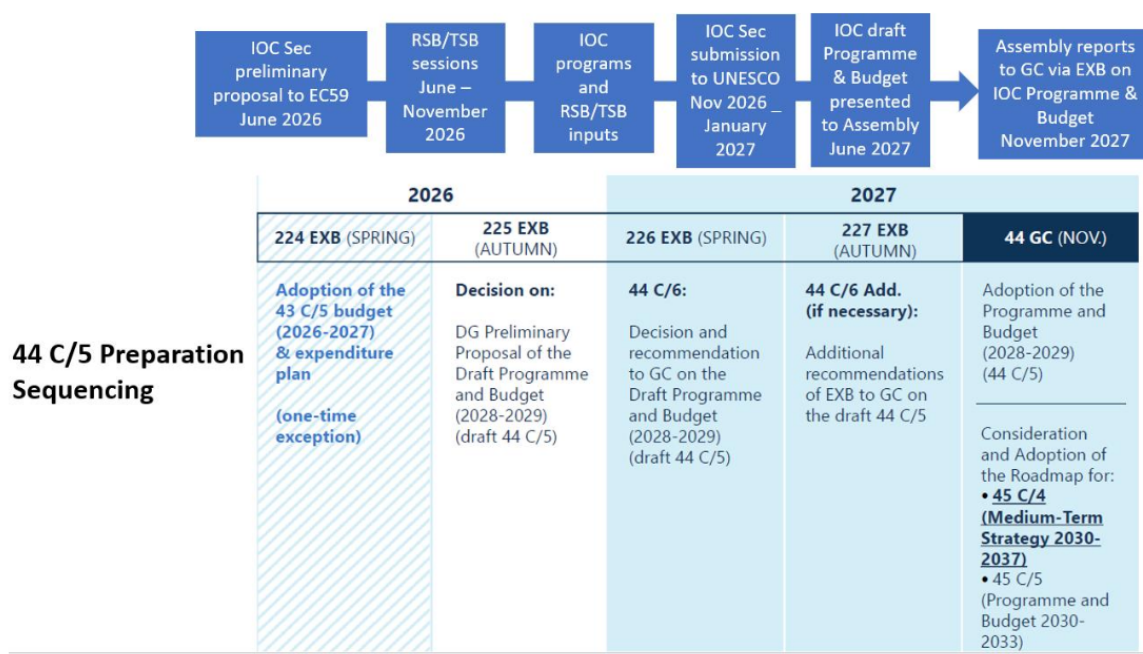
- welcomed the opportunity for closer engagement with the GOOS BioEco Panel, and the opportunity to co-develop an operational biodiversity observing system.
- recommended proactive engagement by the OBIS EC with GOOS to ensure the proposed GOOS Biodiversity Plan aligns with the overall strategic direction of OBIS and report outcomes to the OBIS-SG.
- requested that GOOS in consultation with OBIS calculate the full costs of developing and implementing the GOOS Biodiversity Plan, including the risks of insufficient funding being secured.

There is considerable overlap between the OBIS strategic objectives and this GOOS Biodiversity Plan. GOOS expects support and close collaboration with OBIS. At this moment, a detailed, resourced (financially and staffed) and time-bound implementation plan for the GOOS Biodiversity Plan is not yet available and is expected to be led by the GOOS BioEco panel in close collaboration with key partners including OBIS.

3.7. IOC 2028-2029 work plan and budget (UNESCO 44 C/5)

The IOC secretariat will need to submit its proposed 2028-2029 workplan and budget to UNESCO by January 2027 (see timeline below).

⁷ <https://oceanexpert.org/document/38040>



The IOC Member States (IOC Resolution A-32/4, EC-57/2 and A-33/3) decided that Ocean Observations, data and information management, capacity development and regional subsidiary bodies is the core of IOC and the IOC secretariat wrote in the report to the IOC EC-59⁸ that it shall make every effort to reflect that in the draft programme and budget proposal for 2028–2029. In addition, it also identified seven priority key action areas of which the following five are relevant for OBIS:

- Upscaling and sustaining the Global Ocean Observing System (**GOOS**) infrastructure to address user needs including Member States own needs and providing data and information to support implementation of UN conventions and frameworks including in relation to climate, biodiversity and ocean health.
- Strengthening the International Oceanographic Data and Information Exchange (**IODE**) programme to achieve global coverage and operationalizing a coordinated IOC data architecture.
- Strengthened coordination in relation to **marine biodiversity** to better support Member States in fulfilling commitments in implementation of the Kunming-Montreal **Global Biodiversity Framework** and the **BBNJ** Agreement, as well as regional policy frameworks.
- Supporting **Sustainable Ocean Planning and Management** including through strengthened regional delivery mechanisms and acting as global knowledge partner for Member States' commitments to develop and implement Sustainable Ocean Plans.
- Enhancing Member State's capacity to engage in and benefit from IOC programmes with a particular focus on **Africa** and **SIDS**.

⁸ <https://oceanexpert.org/document/38324>

The UNESCO General Conference in November 2027 will then decide and adopt the IOC workplan and budget. OBIS is expected to propose its 2028-2029 workplan and budget to the IODE-29 Committee session (5-8 Oct 2026), so the IODE Committee can review and submit it to the IOC secretariat by November 2026.

IODE will share a template for IODE programme components and activities to report progress and propose its 2028-2029 work plan and budget. The submission deadline will likely be early September 2026.

The EC-OBIS discussed the following points:

Strengthening the OBIS node network

- The success of OBIS depends on the effective functioning of its node network.
- It is essential to ensure that OBIS nodes and Member States have the capacity and support to meet their needs.
- A priority should be developing tools and services specifically for nodes, including communication support and capacity development.
- The OBIS node onboarding roadmap is already in progress and should remain a priority, particularly if network growth continues to be a strategic objective.

Communications and Member State engagement

- A communications toolkit should help nodes explain the value of OBIS participation in ways that resonate with national priorities. For example, provide ready-to-use messaging such as: *"OBIS is focusing on X in 2027, which aligns with our national priority Y. This is why our participation in OBIS matters."*
- This is an important reminder that the needs of Member States are not always fully aligned with high-level strategic priorities, so communication needs to bridge that gap.

Recognising the value of the network

- The work of OBIS nodes is not sufficiently visible.
- There is also a need to better showcase the significant in-kind contributions and financial resources invested by nodes.
- Demonstrating the collective strength of the OBIS network should become a stronger communication priority.
- An OBIS impact report could help communicate both global and local impacts while illustrating the diversity and heterogeneity of the network.

Clarifying the role of OBIS nodes

- There is considerable variation between nodes.
 - Some function primarily as a single data provider.

- Others coordinate a broader national or regional network of data providers
- The responsibilities and expectations associated with being an OBIS node are not always sufficiently clear.
- Clearer guidance and support will be particularly important for new nodes.

The EC-OBIS proposed the following next steps to prepare for the 2028-2029 OBIS workplan.

Immediate next steps

1. Review the 2026 work plan and identify activities that should roll over into 2027.
2. Develop the methodology for drafting the 2028–2029 work plan:
 - Begin with the Co-Chairs.
 - Consult the Coordination Group (CG).
 - Consult the Steering Group (SG).
 - Final adoption by the Steering Group.

Planning process

- Establish a central Miro board to collect ideas and proposals.
- Run a series of focused planning sprints.
- Group proposals either:
 - by strategic theme, or
 - by level of effort and required resources.
- This naturally creates implementation tiers or phases.

Resource planning

- Explicitly link proposed activities to the human resources required to deliver them.
- Identify resources and staffing required to achieve IOC objectives and targets.
- The work plan should make these resource requirements explicit.

The EC-OBIS stressed that the following should be taken into account:

- Ensure there is clear communication of the IOC high-level goals before detailed planning begins.
- Hold a short preparatory session with the moderators ahead of the planning workshop.
- Networking and capacity development should remain high priorities, especially given that much of the OBIS work plan depends on voluntary contributions.

4. Planning for SG-OBIS

4.1. Pre-SG meeting

The OBIS Steering Group Co-Chairs need to submit the OBIS workplan and budget for 2028-2029 to the 29th IODE Committee that will take place on 5-8 Oct 2026, before the planned 14th IODE Steering Group for OBIS meeting. A pre-SG-OBIS-14 online meeting will take place during Week 39, to capture input from the Nodes and discuss the OBIS workplan and budget for 2028-2029. This meeting will be preceded by a two-streamed asynchronous groundwork that will serve as a base for the discussions: the OBIS Nodes Annual Activity survey, filled out by all Nodes, and a strategic board, contributed to by the OBIS EC. The date for the pre-SG-OBIS-14 online meeting has yet to be determined.

4.2. SG-OBIS-14

Because the pre SG-OBIS meeting in September will discuss and adopt the proposed OBIS workplan and budget for delivery to IODE-29 (5-8 Oct 2026, online), the formal SG-OBIS-14 (11-16 November 2026, Ostend) will provide a platform to deliver on some actions from the work plan, allow OBIS members to get more familiar with the coordination groups and help pave the way forward for implementing the work plan.

Suggestions for agenda items will need to be sent to the secretariat at least one month in advance.

5. Succession of Co-Chairs

5.1. Coordination group Co-Chairs

Coordination Groups were instigated in 2024 at the **SG-OBIS-12** meeting in Gunsan, Republic of Korea with membership nominations made during the SG meeting. Co-Chairs were nominated and appointed during the initial and/or subsequent meetings of each Coordination Group according to the Coordination Group [Terms of Reference](#).

At **SG-OBIS-13** it was agreed that to ensure continuity across annual work plans and enable individuals to establish themselves in the role, that the Terms of Reference for Coordination Group Co-Chairs be updated to reflect that each Coordination Group Co-Chairs appointment would be on the basis of a 2-year term with an optional rolling 2-year additional term subject to approval of SG-OBIS. The SG-OBIS also recommended that the two Coordination Group Co-Chair roles be offset, so that each year there is one CG Co-Chair replaced.

In 2026 the inaugural Co-Chairs of CGs are starting to reach the end of their 2-year terms of appointment, commencing from soon after SG-OBIS-13. Current Co-Chairs and appointments are as follows:

NCG:

- Maria Cornthwaite, OBIS Canada (first term 2024-2026)
- John Nicholls, OPI (first term 2024-2026)

PCG:

- Jon Pye, OTN OBIS (first term 2024-2026)
- Steve Formel, OBIS USA (first term 2024-2026)

DCG:

- Ruben Perez Perez, EurOBIS (first term 2024-2026)
- Victor Chocho, OBIS Ecuador (first term 2025-2027)

There is a need for a process for stepping down and succession of Co-Chairs, including succession planning.

Both NCG Co-chairs announced that they are retiring and stepping down in 2026.

The EC-OBIS recommended that Coordination group co-chairs should inform the secretariat and OBIS co-chairs if they wish to serve a second term or step down at least 3 months prior to the SG meeting. The OBIS secretariat will inform the SG-OBIS accordingly to prepare for succession at the upcoming SG meeting.

Right after the EC-OBIS meeting DCG co-chair Ruben Perez Perez announced that he would not seek a second term and would step down but will remain an active member after the SG-OBIS-14.

5.2. Steering Group Co-Chairs

Ward Appeltans introduced this agenda item. At **SG-OBIS-12**, the Steering Group approved the ToR for the SG-OBIS Co-Chairs, which provided that Co-Chairs are appointed for **two terms of one year each, extendable up to three terms** through mutual agreement and with the endorsement of the Steering Group.

At **SG-OBIS-13** (December 2025), the Steering Group:

- strongly endorsed the continuation of both SG Co-Chairs, noting that this would be the final year for one of the two Co-Chairs;
- updated the ToR for the **Coordination Group (CG) Co-Chairs** so that each appointment is based on a **two-year term with an optional rolling two-year additional term**, subject to approval of SG-OBIS;
- recommended that the two CG Co-Chair roles be **offset**, so that one CG Co-Chair is replaced each year, ensuring continuity; and
- requested that, for transparency, the ToR for the Co-Chairs and OBIS Groups be made available on the OBIS website.

More broadly, as the only IODE Programme Component to have done so, OBIS has aligned its management structure with the new Rules of Procedure for IODE Programme Components. Aligning the tenure of the SG Co-Chairs with the rules of procedure for officers of IOC subsidiary bodies is a natural continuation of that effort.

Issue for consideration

Under the rules of procedure for officers of IOC subsidiary bodies, Co-Chairs may serve **two terms** and, *on an exceptional basis and in the interest of the Commission, both may be eligible for re-election for one further term*. In the IOC, a *term* corresponds to the interval between two ordinary sessions and is therefore **two years**.

In OBIS, by contrast, a term has been defined as **one year** (one ordinary SG-OBIS session). The current SG-OBIS-12 ToR - two one-year terms, extendable to three - therefore has two consequences:

1. Co-Chairs come up for re-election after only **one year** in their role; and
2. The maximum tenure is capped at **three years**.

In practice, after consultation with the current Co-Chairs, it was felt that one year is insufficient time for a Co-Chair to become fully effective in the role, and an annual re-election cycle works against continuity and effectiveness that the Steering Group is seeking. It also creates an inconsistency with the two-year term model that the SG adopted for the Coordination Group Co-Chairs at SG-OBIS-13.

Proposal

The EC-OBIS was invited to discuss the following proposal for submission to SG-OBIS:

- **Retain alignment** with the rules of procedure for officers of IOC subsidiary bodies: SG-OBIS Co-Chairs serve up to **two terms** and, on an exceptional basis and in the interest of the Commission, may each be eligible for re-election for **one further term**.
- **Define one term as two years** for the SG-OBIS Co-Chairs, i.e. each term spans **two ordinary sessions of SG-OBIS** (a Co-Chair chairs two annual SG-OBIS meetings per term).
- As a result, a Co-Chair would normally serve up to **two terms (4 years)**, and a minimum of one term (2 years), replacing the current “two terms of one year, extendable to three terms” provision.
- **Maintain the offsetting principle** so that the two SG Co-Chair appointments are staggered and only one Co-Chair changes at any one time, preserving institutional memory and continuity. This is consistent with the approach adopted for the Coordination Group Co-Chairs at SG-OBIS-13.
- Update the published SG-OBIS Co-Chair ToR accordingly and make the revised ToR available on the OBIS website.

This change keeps OBIS fully aligned with IOC rules of procedure while giving Co-Chairs a realistic period in their role and bringing the SG Co-Chair ToR into line with the two-year-term model already in place for the Coordination Group Co-Chairs.

Transition arrangements

The revised term definition would take effect on its adoption at SG-OBIS-14 and would be applied retrospectively to the service of the current Co-Chairs, so that years already served are counted as part of the revised two-year terms. This allows a smooth move to the new cycle and naturally establishes the staggered rotation:

- **Retrospective application.** The two-year-term definition applies retrospectively to the current Co-Chairs, so that service already completed is recognised in two-year terms rather than one-year terms.
- **Katherine Tattersall: extension to complete two full terms.** Co-Chair **Katherine Tattersall** has served three years. SG-OBIS agrees to **extend her appointment by one further year**, so that she serves **four years in total**, recognised under the revised ToR as **two terms of two years each**. She thereby completes her two terms and steps down at SG-OBIS-15.
- **Dan Lear: continuing.** Co-Chair **Dan Lear**'s service to date (two years) is recognised as his **first two-year term**. He is eligible to be appointed for a **second two-year term** (SG-OBIS-14 to SG-OBIS-16).
- **Offset achieved naturally.** Because Katherine's extended term concludes at **SG-OBIS-15** and Dan's next term concludes at **SG-OBIS-16**, the two Co-Chair seats become **offset by one year**. A new Co-Chair is appointed at SG-OBIS-15 to succeed Katherine (initial term running to SG-OBIS-17). The one-year extension therefore establishes the staggered rotation directly, with no need for an artificial transitional appointment.
- **Steady state.** From this point onwards, both seats follow the standard two-year term and are **offset by one year**, so that **only one Co-Chair changes in any given year**, preserving continuity and institutional memory.

The EC-OBIS discussed this proposal and agreed to bring it forward to the SG-OBIS-14.

6. OBIS involvement in future events

OBIS will be involved in the following meetings in the coming months.

Date	Meeting	Place
30 June - 2 July 2026	IOC Executive Council	Paris, France
2 July 2026	eDNA training course	Online
21-24 July 2026	eDNA training course	Santa Marta, Colombia

25-28 July 2026	OBIS LAC meeting	Santa Marta, Colombia
12-14 August 2026	Genomics Standards Consortium	Rotorua, NZ
21-25 Sep 2026	TDWG 2026 conference	Oslo, Norway
28 Sep-1 Oct 2026	BioEcoOcean + GOOS BioEco panel meeting	Sopot, Poland
28 Sep-2 Oct 2026	GBIF Governing Board	Oslo, Norway
5-9 Oct 2026	IODE-29	Online
19-30 Oct 2026	CBD COP-17	Yerevan, Armenia
24-30 Oct 2026	PICES-2026	Nanaimo, Canada
27 October 2026	OBIS, GBIF, FAIRe Joint Workshop	Seattle, USA
28-30 October 2026	2026 Global eDNA Conference	Seattle, USA
9-12 November 2026	UN World Data Forum	Saudi Arabia
11-16 Nov 2026	SG-OBIS-14	Ostend, Belgium
16 Nov 2026	MARCO-BOLO GA	Bruges, Belgium
17-20 Nov 2026	7th World Conference on Marine Biodiversity	Bruges, Belgium
30 Nov - 3 Dec 2026	IMDIS 2026	Split, Croatia
TBD	OBIS-GBIF DwC-DP workshop	Online
11-22 Jan 2027	BBNJ COP-1	NYC, USA
7-9 April 2027	Ocean Decade Conference	Rio de Janeiro, Brazil

7. Closing

The OBIS Co-Chairs closed the eighth meeting of the OBIS Executive Committee (OBIS-EC-8) at 17:01 CEST. They thanked all Executive Committee members for their active engagement

throughout the meeting and for their continued leadership and commitment to advancing the work of the coordination groups and shaping the future direction of OBIS.

Annex 1: Participants list: Eight session of the OBIS Executive Committee

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